How to get your B2C brand a

CULT FOLLOWING

Creative Performance Marketing

What the research says about brand communities — and how to build a world people choose to belong to.

by Alexandra

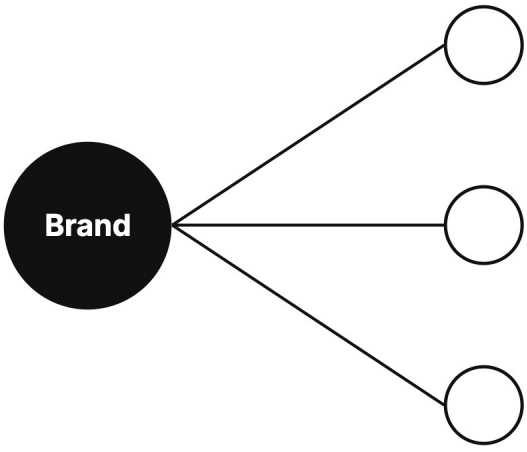
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The big idea

A cult brand isn't a brand with extremely loyal customers.

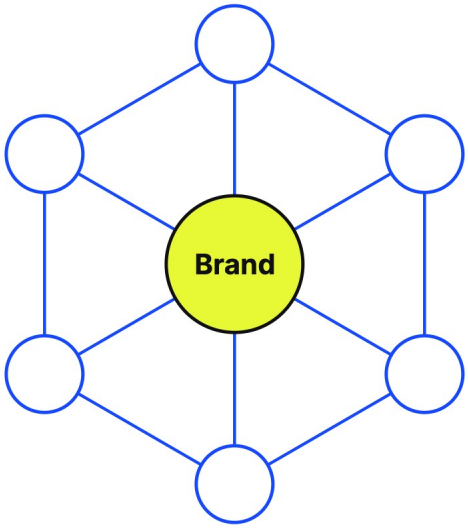
It's a brand around which customers build relationships with each other — and a shared sense of identity.

MOST BRANDS



brand → customer

CULT BRANDS



customer ↔ customer ↔ customer

Researchers rarely call it "cult building". They talk about brand communities, consumer tribes, brand attachment, social identity, authenticity, rituals and co-creation. The common thread: the brand becomes the symbol a social world forms around.

Alexandra's note:
That distinction changes everything. You're not building fans of a product. You're hosting relationships between people.

Three signs of a brand community

From Muñiz & O'Guinn's foundational paper, *Journal of Consumer Research*, 2001

1

Consciousness of kind

"People like us like this."

2

Rituals and traditions

Shared ways of doing, talking about and experiencing the brand.

3

Moral responsibility

Members feel an obligation toward each other — and toward the community itself.

CONSUMER TRIBES

Cova, Kozinets and Shankar describe communities that grow their own myths, values, rituals, vocabulary — even hierarchies.

Eight ingredients of a cult brand

01 A very specific worldview

02 The product as identity

03 A world people can enter

04 Ritual

05 Something to know

06 Participants, not audience

07 Obsession

08 A little weirdness

Our running example: Living Cultures. An imagined fermentation brand — a botanical research laboratory in a forest cottage, obsessed with living things.

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01 A very specific worldview

NOT ~~"We make great skincare."~~

BUT **"We believe in living cultures, slow transformation, botanical knowledge and a more intimate relationship with nature."**

The right person shouldn't just think *"I like their black garlic."* They should think **"These are my people."** That's consciousness of kind — and it starts with a worldview people can recognise.

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02 The product as identity

A PURCHASE

"I bought some black garlic."

AN IDENTITY

"I'm the kind of person who has black garlic fermenting in my kitchen."

Brands carry symbolic and social meaning: people use them to express who they are. That's why a weird, specific product often beats a generic excellent one.

Alexandra's note:
Black garlic is identity-rich.
"Premium wellness powder" isn't.

03 A world people can enter

You aren't just giving people products. You're giving them a place, a language, a mythology — a whole culture.

A PLACE

The forest cottage.



A LANGUAGE

Living cultures. Transformation. Field notes. Botanical observations.

A MYTHOLOGY

Moon cycles. Fermentation. Preservation. Old knowledge + modern science.



OBJECTS

Black garlic. Glass jars. Candles. Pressed flowers. Fermentation vessels.

A VISUAL CODE



Amber glass, handwritten labels, botanical drawings, dark greens, cream paper, strange specimens.

A SET OF PRACTICES

Ferment something. Gather something. Preserve something. Observe something.

That's a culture — not a marketing campaign.

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04 Ritual is central

Give people things they can do — not just things they can buy.



The First Ferment	Every autumn, members make their first ferment of the season.
Black Garlic Sunday	A standing day to cook with it — and show what you made.
The New Moon Ferment	Something new is started with every new moon.
Field Notes	Every batch gets recorded.
The Winter Preservation	Everyone makes the same recipe and shares the results.

~~content~~ → practice

Rituals and traditions are one of the three defining marks of a brand community (Muñiz & O'Guinn).

05 Something to know

Not artificial secrecy. Depth.

"What's the difference between a live ferment and a preserved ferment?"

"Have you tried the No. 03 blackcurrant?"

"Did you see the new Field Notes?"

"What are you fermenting this moon?"

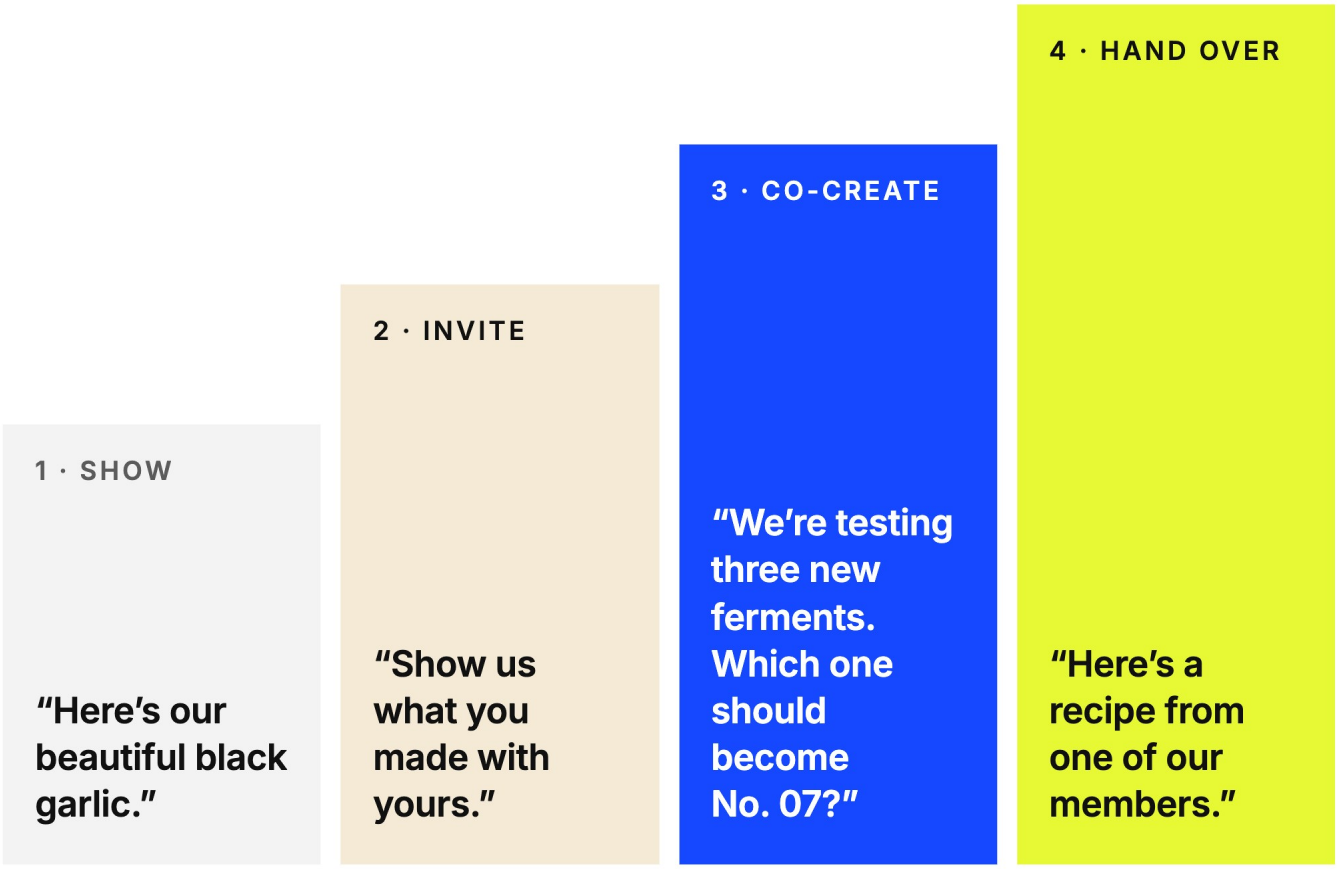
Phrases like these become social markers. Members recognise each other by what they know — the shared vocabulary consumer-tribe researchers describe.

WHAT THE CULTIEST BRANDS GIVE PEOPLE TO LEARN

terminology | techniques | history | references | obscure ingredients | product lore | founder stories | traditions | tiny details

06 Participants, not audience

Don’t make the customer the audience.
Make the customer a participant.



Now the audience is building the mythology with you.

Research on online brand communities finds engagement isn’t passive: it’s sharing, learning, socialising, advocating and co-developing. Members who get real informational and social value are more willing to co-create.

Alexandra’s note:
Every step up hands a little more of the story to your community.

07 Obsession

You can't manufacture authenticity by adding pressed flowers.

Real authenticity is "this company genuinely cares about this strange thing."

Research links perceived authenticity to stronger emotional attachment. And if a founder only uses a theme because it looks good on Instagram, people eventually feel it.

CULT BRANDS CARE TOO MUCH ABOUT ONE THING

Patagonia	environmental philosophy
Harley-Davidson	motorcycle culture
Apple	a design worldview
Aesop	beauty, literature, ritual
LEGO	creative construction
Niche perfumers	perfume as art

Not ~~"We make a good product."~~ But **"We have a particular theory of how life should be lived."**

08 A little weirdness

BROAD

natural wellness | clean living | botanical beauty

Make it broad, and you're competing with everyone.

STRANGE

fermentation | **field botany** | **moon cycles** | **microbiology** | **forest rituals** | **black garlic**

EVERYONE ELSE

"Huh?"

THE RIGHT PERSON

"Oh my god. This is completely my thing."

You don't need everyone. You need the people who get it to **really** get it.

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TWO AMPLIFIERS

Scarcity helps — but it isn't the foundation.

"Cult brand = limited editions" is backwards. Scarcity can amplify desire, but it doesn't create the community. The community comes first — then scarcity can create rituals.

FAKE SCARCITY

"We only made 100 because scarcity sells!"

MEANINGFUL SCARCITY

"This botanical is harvested for three weeks each year."

SOMETHING TO ANTICIPATE:

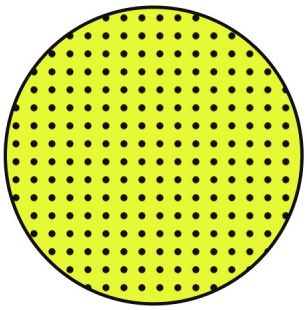
- Spring Ferment · 300 numbered jars
- Moon No. 04
- Annual Forest Collection

The community becomes the marketing.

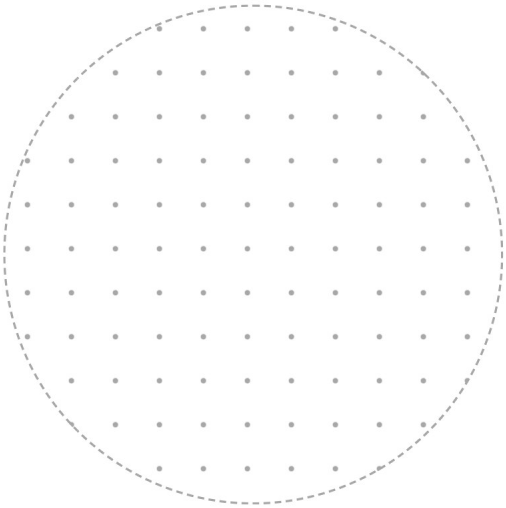
brand → customer	Where every brand starts.
customer → friend	"You HAVE to try this."
customer → customer	"You're into fermentation? You need to know about these people."
community → brand	Members make recipes, photographs, rituals, jokes, collections, reviews, theories and traditions.

Researchers call this value co-creation: members don't just consume the brand, they produce social and cultural value around it. That's when something starts to feel like a cult classic.

Density beats reach



1,000 people who adore you



100,000 people who vaguely recognise you

The 1,000 can be more culturally powerful. Research on brand tribalism links community and social bonds to loyalty. Because the 1,000:

talk about you	buy repeatedly	tell friends	create content	defend you
teach newcomers	collect products	join rituals	feel ownership	

~~Maximum reach~~

MAXIMUM DENSITY OF MEANING AMONG THE RIGHT PEOPLE

THE RESEARCH, AS A FORMULA

Distinctive worldview × identity × ritual × shared language × participation × authenticity × relationships between members × time

= a cult-like brand community

Notice what isn't on the list: Instagram followers. Instagram is just one way to distribute it.

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One name, five meanings

Layered meaning gives a brand longevity. You can write a whole philosophy around it without ever saying “we sell fermented products.”

Living cultures	**Microorganisms.**
Living cultures	**Botanical ecosystems.**
Living cultures	**Human traditions.**
Living cultures	**The culture inside your home.**
Living cultures	**The community around the brand.**

THE DEEPEST VERSION ISN’T “BUY OUR STUFF”. IT’S:

“Come learn how to notice living things.”

Now the customer isn’t joining a food brand. They’re joining a way of paying attention to the world.

THE HEALTHY VERSION

Strong identity without coercion. Belonging without exclusion. Devotion without dependency.

The same mechanisms turn manipulative when a brand engineers dependency, exclusion or fear of leaving. Build a tiny cultural world people *choose* to invest in — one that gives members value, not just takes it.

Build community with me.

I'm Alexandra. If you want a B2C brand people join — not just buy — let's talk about the worldview, rituals and community yours could grow.

Book a discovery call →

SOURCES

Muñiz, A. M. & O'Guinn, T. C. (2001). Brand Community. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 27(4).

Cova, B., Kozinets, R. V. & Shankar, A. (eds.) (2007). *Consumer Tribes*. Butterworth-Heinemann.

Södergren, J. (2021). Brand authenticity: 25 years of research. *International Journal of Consumer Studies*.

Further reading: research on engagement and co-creation in online brand communities, brand tribalism and loyalty, and authenticity and brand attachment.

Living Cultures is an imagined brand, used here as a worked example.